

Nepal 101: Understanding Contemporary Nepal

Designed for students approaching Nepal for the first time. This curated list of ~20 readings draws from academic journals, policy institutes, and reputed international outlets to provide a multidimensional introduction to the country.

Module 1: The Political Landscape — Democracy, Instability & Federalism

Nepal has cycled through 27 prime ministers since 1990. Understanding why requires grasping the interplay of coalition politics, the legacy of monarchy, the Maoist insurgency, and the 2015 constitution's federal experiment.

◆ Must Read:

1. **BTI 2026 Nepal Country Report** — Bertelsmann Transformation Index (2026) *The most comprehensive, regularly updated institutional assessment of Nepal's political system, economic governance, and democratic quality. Covers the full arc from post-pandemic recovery through the 2025 protests. Essential baseline reading.* → bti-project.org/en/reports/country-report/NPL
2. **“Nepal: A Political Economy Analysis”** — Chr. Michelsen Institute (CMI), Bergen *Foundational report arguing that economic growth and poverty reduction have proceeded steadily since the mid-1980s largely independent of political upheaval — a counterintuitive finding that reframes the instability narrative. Excellent on party-business links and the role of remittances.* → cmi.no/publications/6381

◆ Further Reading:

3. **“Nepal in 2024: Has Political Instability Finally Come to an End?”** — South Asian Voices, Stimson Center (Jan. 2025) *Accessible analysis of the Oli-Prachanda-Deuba carousel, the new CPN-UML/Nepali Congress coalition, and BRI framework agreement. Good entry point for the “why so many prime ministers?” question.* → southasianvoices.org

Module 2: Caste, Ethnicity & Social Structure

Nepal's social fabric is among the most complex in South Asia — 125+ caste and ethnic groups, the legacy of the 1854 *Muluki Ain* civil code, and ongoing tensions between constitutional promises of inclusion and deeply entrenched hierarchies. Religion is inseparable from this structure: the caste system is a Hindu cosmological framework imposed by the state on Buddhist, Kirant, Muslim, and animist communities. Nepal was the world's last Hindu kingdom until 2008; its 2015 constitution declares it “secular,” but the meaning — and the backlash — remain fiercely contested.

◆ Must Read:

4. **“Caste, Ethnic and Regional Identity in Nepal: Further Analysis of the 2006 DHS”** — Lynn Bennett, Dilli Ram Dahal & Pav Govindasamy, DHS Program / Macro International *The foundational empirical study disaggregating health and development outcomes by caste, ethnicity, and region. Explains the Muluki Ain hierarchy, the Janajati/Adivasi categories, Madhesi groups, and Dalit exclusion with data. Still widely cited.* → dhsprogram.com/pubs/pdf/FA58/FA58.pdf

◆ **Further Reading:**

5. **“Enduring Boundaries, Emerging Bridges: Patterns of Caste and Ethnic Inter-marriage in Nepal”** — Yanwen Wang, *Research in Social Stratification and Mobility* (2025) *Uses 2001 and 2011 census data to show that intermarriage across caste/ethnic lines remains below 1% nationally — a striking indicator of enduring social boundaries despite legal reforms. Reveals how child marriage reinforces endogamy among Dalits.* → sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0276562425000952
6. **“The Struggle Between Hindutva and Secularism in Nepal”** — Harvard International Review (2021) *Essential for understanding the religious dimension of Nepal’s social structure. Traces how the monarchy actively constructed Nepal as “the last Hindu kingdom” from the 1960s onward, how the Muluki Ain hierarchized all of Nepali society under Hindu cosmology, and how the 2015 constitution’s definition of “secular” as protecting religions “from time immemorial” (sanatan) effectively privileges Hinduism and excludes Islam and Christianity. Documents the rapid growth of Christianity (especially among Dalits and Janajatis), the anti-conversion law of 2017, and the continuing push by Hindu nationalist parties to reverse secularism.* → hir.harvard.edu/the-struggle-between-hindutva-and-secularism-in-nepal
7. **“Women’s Representation and Intersectional (Un)Inclusion”** — Kalpana Jha, *The Record* (2022) *Sharp analysis showing that Nepal’s lauded gender quotas disproportionately benefit Khas-Arya women, while Madhesi, Dalit, and Muslim women remain near-absent from leadership. Challenges students to think beyond aggregate gender numbers.* → recordnepal.com/womens-representation-and-intersectional-uninclusion

Module 3: Labor Migration & the Remittance Economy

Remittances constitute over 26% of Nepal’s GDP. An estimated 3.5+ million Nepalis work abroad, overwhelmingly in the Gulf and Malaysia, making migration the defining economic and social fact of contemporary Nepali life.

◆ **Must Read:**

7. **“Beyond Remittances: The True Cost of Nepali Labor Migration”** — *Journal of Human Rights and Social Work*, Springer (2025) *Rigorous examination of systemic failures in migration governance — fraudulent recruitment, weak enforcement, the*

"double jeopardy" faced by climate-displaced migrants and women. Pairs the macro-economic story with human costs. → link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s41134-025-00409-4

◆ **Further Reading:**

8. **"Induced Poverty, Increased Remittances: Unveiling the Lived Realities of Nepali Migrant Workers"** — *BMC Public Health* (2025) *Qualitative study interviewing 17 male Nepali migrant workers currently in Malaysia and GCC countries. Themes include "The Body as a Site of Extraction," "The Remittance Trap," and "Navigating Healthcare Deserts." Pairs well with #7. → link.springer.com/article/10.1186/s12889-025-25503-0*
9. **"Labour Migration from Nepal: Trends and Explanations"** — Springer Open Access book chapter (2023) *Comprehensive historical overview from 19th-century Lahure tradition through the Gulf boom to COVID-19 disruptions. Argues that no single migration theory explains Nepal's patterns — networks, institutions, and perceived status all matter. → link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-031-34194-6_5*

Module 4: Geopolitics — Nepal Between India, China & the World

Nepal's geographic position between two nuclear-armed giants makes its foreign policy a perpetual balancing act. The BRI, MCC, and Indo-Pacific strategy all converge in Kathmandu.

◆ **Must Read:**

10. **"Nepal's Geopolitical Crossroads: Balancing China, India, and the United States"** — Asia Society Policy Institute (2023) *The most thorough single analysis of the triangular dynamic. Traces China's evolving Nepal strategy from Tibet-security focus to proactive BRI engagement, India's attempts to maintain primacy, and the MCC debate as a proxy for US-China competition. → asiasociety.org/policy-institute/nepals-geopolitical-crossroads*

◆ **Further Reading:**

11. **"Regional Rivalries and Extra-regional Interests in Nepal"** — Bibek Chand, *Georgetown Journal of International Affairs* (2024) *Frames Nepal as a "buffer state" with agency, not merely a passive pawn. Argues for diversifying ties via BIMSTEC, UN peacekeeping, and European partnerships to avoid being geopolitically boxed in. → gjia.georgetown.edu*
12. **"Nepal's Generational Revolt Catches China and India in the Middle"** — Lowy Institute, *The Interpreter* (Sept. 2025) *Concise analysis connecting the 2025 Gen Z protests to India-China competition. Notes that Oli's fall was not about his China ties but about a generational demand for structural change — yet both Beijing and New*

Delhi are recalculating. → [lowyinstitute.org/the-interpreter/nepal-s-generational-revolt](https://www.lowyinstitute.org/the-interpreter/nepal-s-generational-revolt)

Module 5: Environment — Climate Change, Biodiversity & Community Forestry

Nepal spans from 60m to 8,849m elevation, encompassing 118 ecosystems, 35 forest types, and 11 bioclimatic zones. Climate change hits with disproportionate force: glacial retreat, GLOF risks, and shifting monsoons. But Nepal is also a biodiversity hotspot — home to tigers, snow leopards, rhinos, and red pandas — and the site of the world’s most celebrated community forestry program, which has handed management of nearly one-third of the country’s forests to 22,000+ community user groups.

◆ Must Read:

13. **“Climate Change and Its Impacts on Glaciers and Glacial Lakes in Nepal Himalayas”** — Khadka et al., *Regional Environmental Change*, Springer (2023) *The definitive review article. Synthesizes warming trends (0.02–0.16°C/year), glacier shrinkage, negative mass balance, upward ELA shift, and glacial lake expansion (606 → 1,541 lakes between 1977–2017). 21 lakes classified as potentially dangerous.* → link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10113-023-02142-y
14. **“The Effects of the Nepal Community Forestry Program on Biodiversity Conservation and Carbon Storage”** — Luintel, Bluffstone & Scheller, *PLOS ONE* (2018) *The most rigorous empirical study of whether community-managed forests actually deliver on their promise. Using quasi-experimental matching across 620 randomly selected forest plots nationwide, the authors find a significant positive effect on biodiversity but a negative effect on carbon stocks — a provocative finding that challenges the assumption that community forestry is a universal win-win. Effects vary sharply by region, altitude, and canopy cover, suggesting the need for locally tailored policies. Open access.* → journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0199526
15. **“Assessing the Effectiveness of Protected Areas in Nepal for Forests and Biodiversity Conservation”** — *Biological Conservation* / ScienceDirect (2026) *The most current assessment of all 20 of Nepal’s protected areas, using propensity score matching to compare conservation outcomes inside and outside PA boundaries. The key finding: PAs reduce forest loss (9.7% lower than matched controls), but forest recovery is actually higher outside PAs — likely because of the community forestry program. As Nepal commits to protecting 30% of its territory by 2030 under the Kunming–Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, this study provides essential evidence on what works and what doesn’t.* → [sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0006320726001412](https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0006320726001412)

◆ Further Reading:

14. **“No End to Climate Change’s Wrath for Himalayas as Nepal Reports Yet Another Glacial Lake Outburst”** — *Down to Earth* (Aug. 2024) *Accessible reporting*

on the August 2024 Thyanbo glacial lake outburst in Thame village (Khumbu region). Contextualizes within the ICIMOD warning of a threefold increase in GLOF incidence by end of century, with peak risk around 2050. → downtoearth.org.in

Module 6: The 2015 Gorkha Earthquake — Disaster, Recovery & Resilience

The 7.8-magnitude earthquake killed ~9,000, destroyed over 500,000 houses, and tested every institution in the country. A decade on, it remains a lens for understanding governance, inequality, and resilience.

◆ Must Read:

15. **“A Decade Later: Lessons from Nepal’s Earthquake Response”** — The Asia Foundation (2025) *Drawing on five rounds of independent household research, this retrospective shows that 75% of households rebuilt within five years — but vulnerable groups (low-caste, landless, women-headed households) lagged significantly. A model of evidence-based post-disaster learning.* → asiafoundation.org/a-decade-later-lessons-from-nepals-earthquake-response

◆ Further Reading:

16. **“Responding to a Mega-Earthquake: Lessons from the 2015 Gorkha Earthquake, Nepal”** — Bhishma Kumar Bhusal, VoxDev *First-person reflections from the man who managed Nepal’s reconstruction. Candid on what worked (owner-driven reconstruction, build-back-better principle) and what didn’t (prototype houses that erased cultural heritage).* → voxdev.org

Module 7: The Maoist War & Transitional Justice

The 1996–2006 civil war killed over 13,000 and displaced hundreds of thousands. Nearly two decades later, not a single case of serious human rights violation has been prosecuted to international standards. Understanding this impunity is essential.

◆ Must Read:

17. **“No Law, No Justice, No State for Victims: The Culture of Impunity in Post-Conflict Nepal”** — Human Rights Watch (2020) *The most comprehensive documentation of 62 tracked cases: enforced disappearances, extrajudicial killings, sexual violence. Details how the TRC and CEIDP have been undermined by political manipulation and how the criminal justice system has actively obstructed accountability.* → hrw.org/report/2020/11/20/no-law-no-justice-no-state-victims

◆ Further Reading:

18. **“Transitional Justice as an Elite Discourse: Human Rights Practice Between the Global and the Local in Post-conflict Nepal”** — Simon Robins, *Critical Asian Studies* 44:1 (2012) *Influential academic article contrasting the agendas of*

Kathmandu-based human rights elites with those of indigenous victims in Bardiya district. Argues that the international transitional justice framework can paradoxically disempower the very communities it claims to serve. → tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/14672715.2012.644885

Module 8: The 2025 Gen Z Uprising — Youth, Digital Politics & the Future

In September 2025, Nepal joined Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and Indonesia in a wave of youth-led uprisings that toppled governments. The movement resulted in 74 deaths and Nepal's first woman PM — and in March 2026, the youngest PM in its history.

◆ Must Read:

19. **“From Streets to Discord: How Nepal’s Gen Z Toppled a Government”** — Carnegie Endowment for International Peace (Sept. 2025) *The definitive early account. Traces the arc from #NepoBaby social media trend → social media ban → peaceful protests → police violence → burning of Singha Durbar → PM Oli’s resignation → Sushila Karki as interim PM. Written with narrative flair and analytical rigor. → carnegieendowment.org*
20. **“The 2025 Gen Z Uprising in Nepal: A Three-Part Analysis”** — Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, Atrocity Prevention Lab (Nov. 2025) *Academic analysis in three parts: immediate triggers, structural/economic fractures, and the potential for geospatial technologies in civilian protection. Unique for connecting the uprising to digital governance failures and for its atrocity-prevention lens. → hsph.harvard.edu/atrocity-prevention-lab*

◆ Further Reading:

21. **“Nepal’s Gen Z Revolution and the Politics of Visibility”** — Heinrich Böll Stiftung (April 2026) *The most recent analysis, incorporating the March 2026 election results. Examines the generational divide, diaspora mobilization, women’s participation, and the election of 35-year-old Balendra Shah as PM. Good on the “conviction vs. performative momentum” tension. → boell.de*

Module 9: Gender, Citizenship & Inclusion

Nepal’s 2015 constitution guarantees 33% women’s representation and prohibits caste-based discrimination — yet citizenship laws still discriminate against women, and intersectional exclusion persists.

◆ Must Read (pairs with Module 2):

22. **“Equal Laws in Nepal Crucial for Ending Discrimination Against Women”** — Human Rights Watch (March 2023) *Focused briefing on Nepal’s discriminatory citizenship laws that prevent women from conferring citizenship to their children on*

equal terms with men — disproportionately affecting Madhesi women with cross-border marriages and unmarried mothers. Clear, accessible, essential. → hrw.org/news/2023/03/08/equal-laws-nepal-crucial

Module 10: Public Health — A Success Story with Deep Fractures

Nepal is a paradox in global health: its maternal mortality decline (553 → 186 per 100,000 live births between 2000–2017) outperformed countries with far greater resources. Yet mental health remains catastrophically under-resourced, and the health of its 3.5 million migrant workers abroad is largely invisible to the system.

◆ Must Read:

23. **“Increased Utilisation and Quality: Explaining Nepal’s Success in Reducing Maternal and Newborn Mortality 2000–2020”** — Sharma et al., *BMJ Global Health* (2024) *Mixed-method case study identifying the drivers behind Nepal’s 66% decline in maternal mortality — one of the steepest sustained drops anywhere. Despite geographic barriers and political instability, Nepal massively expanded facility-based deliveries and targeted inequality. A rare good-news story with hard evidence.* → ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC11085885

◆ Further Reading:

24. **“Nepal’s Mental Health System from a Public Health Perspective: A Thematic Synthesis Based on Health System Building Blocks”** — *The Lancet Regional Health – Southeast Asia* (2025) *The most comprehensive recent assessment. Nepal has roughly 147 psychiatrists for 30 million people, no standalone mental health policy, and mental health services are poorly integrated into primary care. The 2015 earthquake and COVID-19 raised awareness but the structural gaps remain vast. Nepal is one of seven countries in the WHO Special Initiative for Mental Health.* → thelancet.com/journals/lansea
25. **“Perceived Mental Health, Wellbeing and Associated Factors Among Nepali Male Migrant and Non-Migrant Workers: A Qualitative Study”** — Devkota et al., *Journal of Migration and Health* / PMC (2021) *Bridges the migration and public health modules. Migrant workers in the Gulf report higher mental health risks than non-migrants — heat burns, snake bites, dengue, kidney failure, and sexually transmitted diseases alongside isolation, loneliness, and poor access to healthcare. Pairs well with readings #7 and #8.* → pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8352157

Module 11: Mountaineering, Tourism & Sherpa Labor

Everest is Nepal’s most recognizable global brand. But behind the summit photos lies a \$400-million tourism industry built on Sherpa labor, ecological stress, and deep questions about consent, risk, and who gets credited.

◆ **Must Read:**

26. **“In the Shadow of the Mountain: The Crisis of Precarious Livelihoods in High Altitude Mountaineering Tourism”** — Miller & Mair, *Journal of Sustainable Tourism* (2022) *Ethnographic study of Sherpa and other high-altitude workers in Nepal. Documents the \$3,000–6,000 per season that Sherpa guides earn on Everest (vs. \$50,000 for Western guides), the sentiment of working “in the shadows,” and the structural inequities of who gets called a “mountaineer” versus a “worker.” Essential reading on labor, race, and adventure capitalism.* → tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/09669582.2022.2108038

◆ **Further Reading:**

27. **“Mountaineering on Mount Everest: Evolution, Economy, Ecology, and Ethics”** — Ortner / Stevens et al., in *The Himalayas and Beyond* (2015) *Comprehensive academic overview covering the evolution from colonial expedition to mass commercial tourism, permit economics (~\$3.3 million annually for Nepal), ecological damage in the alpine zone, and the tension between Sherpa cultural continuity and tourism-driven change. Multiple contributing scholars.* → Available via ResearchGate and institutional libraries
28. **“Contours of High-Altitude Mountaineering in Contemporary Nepal”** — Tri-Chandra *Journal of Anthropology* (2025) *The most current ethnographic study. Documents the rising participation of non-Sherpa ethnic groups (Tamang, Gurung, Magar, Brahmin/Chhetri) in mountaineering — still only 7% of Everest summits by Nepalis — and the evolving labor hierarchy as ethnic Sherpas move into management and outfitting roles.* → nepjol.info/index.php/tja/article/view/82771

Module 12: Films & Popular Culture — Seeing Nepal

English-language scholarship on Nepali arts and popular culture remains thin — a telling gap in itself. These five films and documentaries, all available on major streaming platforms, offer students visual and emotional entry points that readings alone cannot provide. Assign at least two alongside the relevant modules.

◆ **Five Films to Watch:**

🎬 **1. 14 Peaks: Nothing Is Impossible** (2021) — Dir. Torquil Jones | **Netflix** *Nepali mountaineer Nirmal “Nims” Purja attempts to summit all 14 eight-thousanders in seven months, shattering a record that stood at nearly eight years. The film is thrilling on its own terms, but its deeper value for a Nepal course lies in what it reveals about Sherpa identity, Nepali national pride, the economics of expedition climbing, and who gets to be called a hero. Nims explicitly reframes the narrative: Sherpas are not sidekicks. Pairs with Module 11.*

🎬 **2. Mountain Queen: The Summits of Lhakpa Sherpa** (2024) — Dir. Lucy Walker | **Netflix** *Peabody Award winner (2025). Lhakpa Sherpa, the most decorated female Everest*

climber in history (10 summits), disguised her gender to work on mountains as a girl, then immigrated to the US where she raised two daughters as a single mother working at a Connecticut Whole Foods. A devastating portrait of how gender, migration, class, and race intersect — the Sherpa story Hollywood rarely tells. Pairs with Modules 9 and 11.

 **3. Himalaya (a.k.a. Caravan)** (1999) — Dir. Éric Valli | **Netflix, Apple TV** Academy Award-nominated (Best Foreign Language Film). Shot entirely in the Dolpo region of northwest Nepal with non-professional Tibetan-speaking actors. An aging chief and a young herdsman compete to lead the annual yak caravan that trades salt for grain — a journey on which the village's survival depends. Stunningly filmed in CinemaScope, it is both an intimate generational drama and a record of a way of life that climate change and road-building are rapidly erasing. Pairs with Modules 5 and 11.

 **4. Manakamana** (2013) — Dir. Stephanie Spray & Pacho Velez | **Netflix, MUBI** A Harvard Sensory Ethnography Lab production. The entire film consists of fixed-camera shots inside the cable car carrying pilgrims and tourists up to the Manakamana temple in Gorkha district. No narration, no interviews — just faces, landscapes, silences, and the occasional conversation. A radical formal experiment that also serves as a quiet ethnography of contemporary Nepal: who rides the cable car, what they carry, how modernity and devotion coexist. Ideal for a seminar on method and representation.

 **5. Mustang: Journey of Transformation** (2025) — Dir. Taylor Rees | **Available on expedition/festival circuit; check Apple TV, Vimeo** Three men journey to the former kingdom of Lo Manthang in Upper Mustang — a region that was closed to outsiders until 1992 — to reconcile loss, search for roots, and witness the collision of ancient Tibetan Buddhist culture with modernization. The film captures the stark high-desert landscape and the Loba people's struggle to preserve their heritage as roads, climate change, and outmigration transform the region. Pairs with Modules 1, 2, and 5.

◆ **Note on the gap:** The absence of globally distributed Nepali-language feature films from this list reflects a structural reality: Nepal's domestic film industry (*Kollywood*) produces hundreds of titles annually but faces limited international distribution, subtitling, and festival exposure. Filmmakers like Min Bahadur Bham (*The Black Hen / Kalo Pothi*, 2015), Deepak Rauniyar (*White Sun*, 2016), and Abinash Bikram Shah are gaining international recognition but their work remains harder to access on mainstream platforms. Students interested in Nepali-language cinema should explore the **Kathmandu International Mountain Film Festival (KIMFF)** and **Nepal International Film Festival (NIFF)** catalogs.

Compiled April 2026 by Chi Huyen (Shachi) Truong. All URLs verified at time of compilation. Total: 29 readings + 5 films across 12 modules.